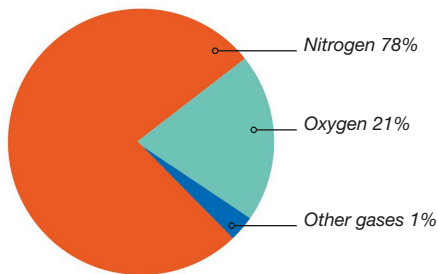


Nitrogen Group

Another name for the members of this group is the “pnictogens”, which comes from the Greek word for “to choke”. This refers to nitrogen’s tendency to cause choking in the absence of oxygen. However, nitrogen, as well as phosphorus, are essential ingredients in bones and muscles. This group includes non-metals, semi-metals, and metals.

Atmospheric nitrogen

The relatively unreactive nitrogen is the most abundant gas in Earth’s atmosphere. Every living thing needs nitrogen compounds to grow, but most cannot use pure nitrogen. Instead, bacteria in soil convert the gas into useable compounds, which are collected by plants via their roots. Animals take in nitrogen through food.



Gases in Earth's atmosphere

Burning phosphorus

The most reactive member of the group is phosphorus. Some forms of it will catch fire on contact with air. A safer version is used in matches, where phosphorus is mixed into the rough strip on the box. When the match is rubbed along here, the phosphorus heats up and reacts with the match head, setting it alight.

Striking a matchstick

